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[265 Word Abstract]

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Title of Proposed Paper:

Gianni Vattimo and the Possibility of Religious Pluralism in Postmodern Christianity

In this essay, I argue that religious plurality is possible and expected, so long as one seeks to de-emphasize the rules of metaphysics. Overcoming metaphysical standards within the Church, a theme common among many Continental philosophers, offers an opportunity to annul the being-language associated with God and thus make possible invitations for non-Christians to participate in a dialogue on the divine.

To support this argument, I rely on the Italian Gianni Vattimo's philosophy of *pensiero debole* (weak thought) and *teologia debole* (weak theology). His work engages the theology of the Roman Catholic Church, often critically, suggesting the dissolution of traditional Thomism, offering instead a philosophy grounded in the charitable self-abasement of God and hermeneutical nihilism. The result is a Christianity void of "fundamentalist superstitions" and the "disciplinary masks" found within the institutional Church (Vattimo, *After Christianity* [2002], 91). He does not, however, advocate a complete dismantle of the Church, especially its ceremonial and ascetical attributes. Rather, Vattimo proposes a postmodern theology which emphasizes a 'secularization' that places Christianity in a genealogical context; one that identifies the faith as part of Western culture. The resulting philosophy opens the doors to a theology which confronts a society that requires a reasoned, logical thought process aimed at developing a Christianity that fits within a growing secularized context.

To conclude, I suggest a return to the cardinal virtue of *caritas*, found in both Gianni Vattimo's philosophy and Jean-Luc Marion's phenomenology. The emphasis placed on this Christian attribute would permit the Church to follow through on Pope Francis's call for Mercy, while also inviting a pluralism into the postmodern church.